

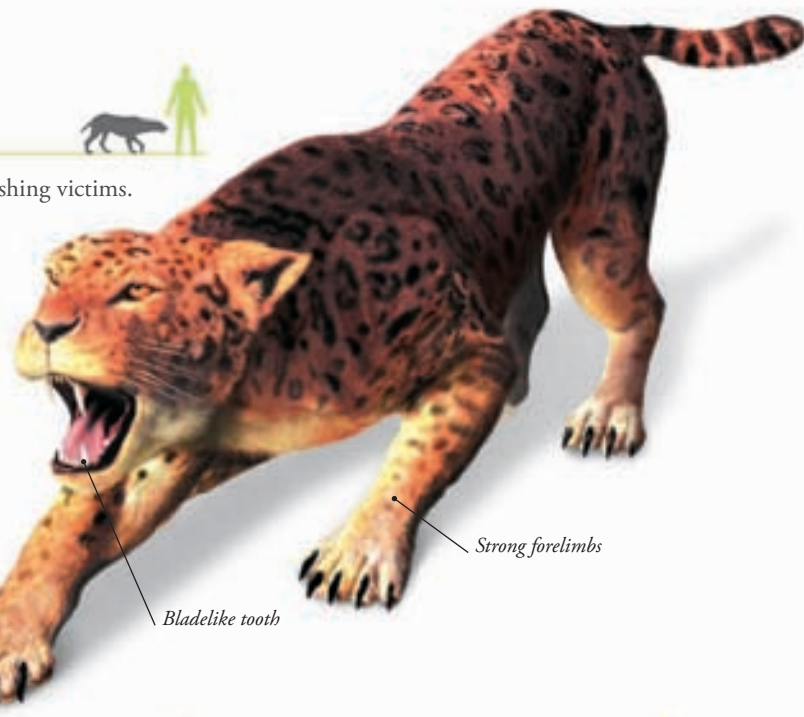
Dinofelis

DIE-no-FEE-liss

- **When** 5–1 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Africa, Europe, Asia, N. America
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 5 ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Meat

Dinofelis (“terrible cat”) was about the same size as modern forest-dwelling cats, such as leopards and jaguars. Like these cats, it may even have had a spotted or striped coat that helped it to remain hidden in the undergrowth while it kept a lookout for prey. *Dinofelis* stalked its prey in the forest, hiding

behind trees before ambushing victims. Its prominent front teeth were shorter and less flattened than those of other saber-toothed cats but were just as deadly. In Africa, its bones have been found near the sites of early humans, which suggests that it may have preyed on them, too.



Cave hyena

cave high-EE-na

- **When** 2 million–10,000 years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe, Asia
- **Habitat** Grassland
- **Length** 5 ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Meat

A hunter and scavenger, the cave hyena fed on wild horses, woolly rhinos, deer, and humans in ice age Europe and Asia. Recent tests of DNA from fossils show it was the same species as the modern African spotted hyena (*Crocuta crocuta*), but larger and with longer legs.



Ictitherium

ICK-tee-theeri-um

- **When** 13–5 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe, Asia, Africa
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 4 ft (1.2 m)
- **Diet** Insects



Ictitherium was an early member of the hyena family. However, with its long body and short legs, it looked more like a civet (a tree-climbing, nocturnal mammal) than a modern hyena. It was probably an insect-eater, but may have also fed on small mammals and lizards.

Machairodus

mah-CARE-oh-duss

- **When** 12 million–125,000 years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** N. America, Africa, Europe, Asia
- **Habitat** Woodlands, grassland
- **Length** 5 ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Meat

Large and ferocious, *Machairodus* was a saber-toothed cat, although its canines were shaped more like a knife blade than those of *Smilodon*. Like most early cats, it was an ambush predator, since its legs were too short to sustain a long chase. Species that evolved later and lived on the plains had longer front limbs, which shows that they were traveling farther to hunt and were running after their prey.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Sharp teeth
- Powerful jaws and neck muscles
- Strong forelimbs
- Clawed feet

When

The first catlike mammals lived about 35 million years ago, in the Paleogene Period. They evolved into the family of modern cats that include lions and jaguars.

